



## MONTHLY UPDATE

# Sao Tome and Principe: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-06 · 9 systems and instruments tracked

*Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.*

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · DPI · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · GEOPOLITICS

## Summary of the month

Nine rows moved, and the month's substance is in the registers and the statistics rather than in any new system. The electoral commission [opened a consultation window on a provisional roll of 146,510 voters](#) after finding the automatic civil-registry derivation had omitted 1,860 eligible people, a system inheriting the flaws of the register it was built from. The social protection directorate [put the single social registry at about 12,500 households, roughly a quarter of the population](#), stating unprompted that registration is not a poverty count. The central bank [refreshed its payment-system statistics on 28 August](#), a bank [became the first in the country certified to a quality management standard](#), and the university [graduated at least 94 students, 79 of them women](#). Two districts [turned resident-identified priorities into completed works in six and a half months](#). A procurement agency [extended the tender for the state utility's new management-information system](#) without disclosing value or new deadline, a UN agency [handed computing equipment to the tax directorate](#) with neither value nor schedule attached, the United States mission [marked fifty years of relations](#), and a second information-exchange agreement with the same foreign counterpart on money laundering [is to be signed](#), with no date or text held.

## Governance

### Data protection

A further agreement between the two jurisdictions on [exchanging information to combat money laundering is to be signed](#). It is the second instrument with the same counterpart and the base holds no signature date or text for it.

### Standards

[BGFI Bank Sao Tome became the first bank in the country certified to ISO 9001:2015](#), the certificate presented at a ceremony marking 55 years of its group in the presence of members of the government, the central bank and the diplomatic corps. The national quality body, an autonomous institute under the finance ministry, is [the country's correspondent member of the international standards organisation](#) - the membership category for states without a fully developed national standards activity. A single private certification is the whole of the month's adoption record, and no public body is recorded as certified to any international standard.

## DPI

### Digital Payments and Fintech

The central bank [refreshed its payment-system statistics on 28 August 2026](#), recording the internet banking series from 2014 and the interbank clearing series from 2013 as last published that day, and the payment-card operations series from 2011 as last published on 3 July. Its [payment systems report, which sets out developments in the national payment system and the most important clearing and settlement events](#), was last published on 17 April 2026. The instrument set behind the series has not changed - debit cards on a single domestic network, cheques and bank transfers - and no mobile money or wallet product appears anywhere in it.

### Registries

The National Electoral Commission opened a [1–8 August 2026 public-consultation window](#) on a provisional roll of 146,510 registered voters, ahead of the 27 September elections, after finding the automatically-compiled roll had omitted 1,860 eligible voters through a process failure — alongside 1,976 newly-eligible 18-year-olds added in the ordinary course. Address and polling-station changes can only be made in person or via WhatsApp; there is no online self-service channel, a gap the roll's own automatic-derivation design has not closed. [The Direção da Proteção Social reported the Cadastro Social Único covered about 12,500 households](#), roughly a quarter of the population, and stated explicitly that registration does not equal a poverty diagnosis — a distinction the agency drew unprompted, suggesting the figure was already being read the other way in public discussion. This update follows a mass population-registration exercise the government ran in January and February 2026, though no source held gives that earlier exercise's own separate coverage figure for a direct year-on-year comparison against it.

### Sectoral management information systems

[AFAP extended the deadline of tender ref. 45-G](#) on 7 August 2026 for supply, installation, training and commissioning of a new management-information system for EMAE, the state water and electricity utility. The original terms, contract value and new deadline are not stated in the source held — a scanned procurement notice with no text layer, so only the notice's own headline could be read for this pass.

### Other GovTech and e-Gov

The month's government-systems movement is hardware. A UN agency [handed computing equipment to the tax directorate under an EU-funded regional programme, to modernise tax administration and the handling of fiscal data](#). No value is stated for the equipment and no delivery schedule accompanies it, so what the base holds is a donation and an intention rather than a system with a capability attached.

## Capacity

### Training and skills

The national university [graduated at least 94 students on 24 August 2026, 79 of them women](#), across courses it lists as agronomy, languages, law, public relations, public administration, tourism and technologies. The source gives no breakdown by course, so how many are computing or telecommunications graduates is unstated, and [no official publication counts graduates by field of study, ICT graduate destinations or the size of the national ICT professional workforce](#). It is the largest single addition to the graduate stock reported in this window, against [a domestic information and communication sector of six enterprises employing 209 people](#).

## Inclusion

### Access to services

Two communities turned resident-identified priorities into completed works in six and a half months through pilot participatory budgeting exercises: [a paved stretch of the Estrada da Oficina in Alges, Cantagalo district, and a new water capture and distribution system with a decanting process at Ribeira Palma Praia, Lemba district](#). The project was a partnership between two civil-society organisations and the two district councils, with support from a Portuguese municipality and the European Union, and residents took part at every stage from identifying the problem to delivering the investment. The publisher is the partner municipality rather than a Sao Tomean body, and the source describes pilot experiences rather than a national participatory budgeting system.

## Geopolitics

### US / hyperscaler activities

The United States mission [marked fifty years of diplomatic relations at a reception on 20 August 2026](#), at which the charge d'affaires met the foreign minister and the delegation visited the country's coastguard headquarters and maritime operations control centre, described as ongoing cooperation on maritime security. The release names the arrival of Starlink satellite internet among recent initiatives. The standing bilateral position is unchanged: [there is no bilateral investment treaty and no taxation treaty with the United States, and the development finance corporation is authorised to operate in the country but has run no programmes there](#).

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## ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| EDITION         | 2026-09-06                                                                                                                                                        |
| CURRENT EDITION | <a href="https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/STP/STP-monthly.html">https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/STP/STP-monthly.html</a>                     |
| THIS FILE       | <a href="https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/STP/STP-monthly-2026-09-06.pdf">https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/STP/STP-monthly-2026-09-06.pdf</a> |
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This is a dated edition and is not revised after publication. If a figure here has moved, the current edition will say so.